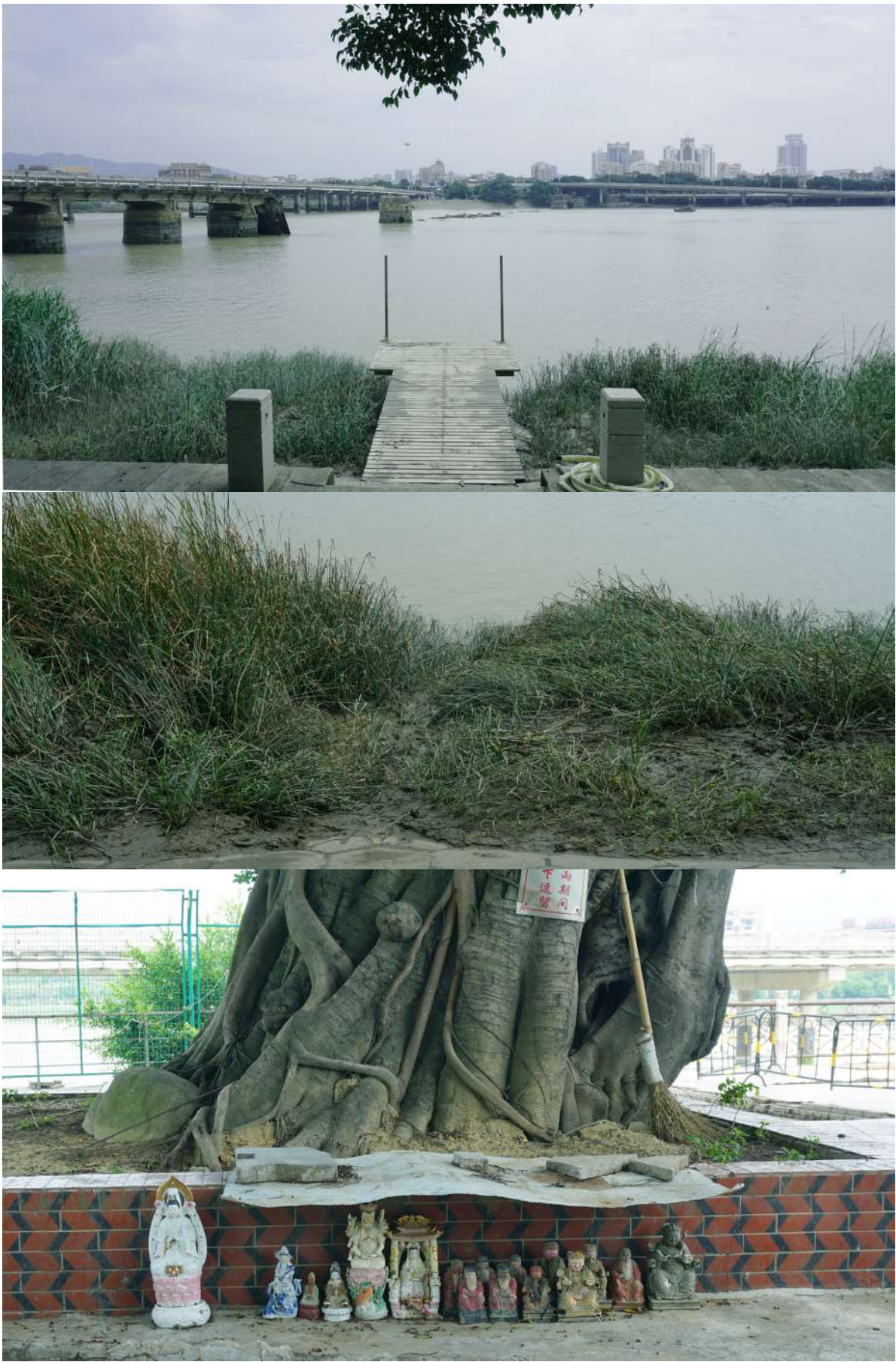


CHAPTER 2

THE CULTURAL LANDSCAPE OF JUBAO



Images show the view looking towards Jubao from the other side of river Jin. Also the tree and the Genius loci next to the river bank.

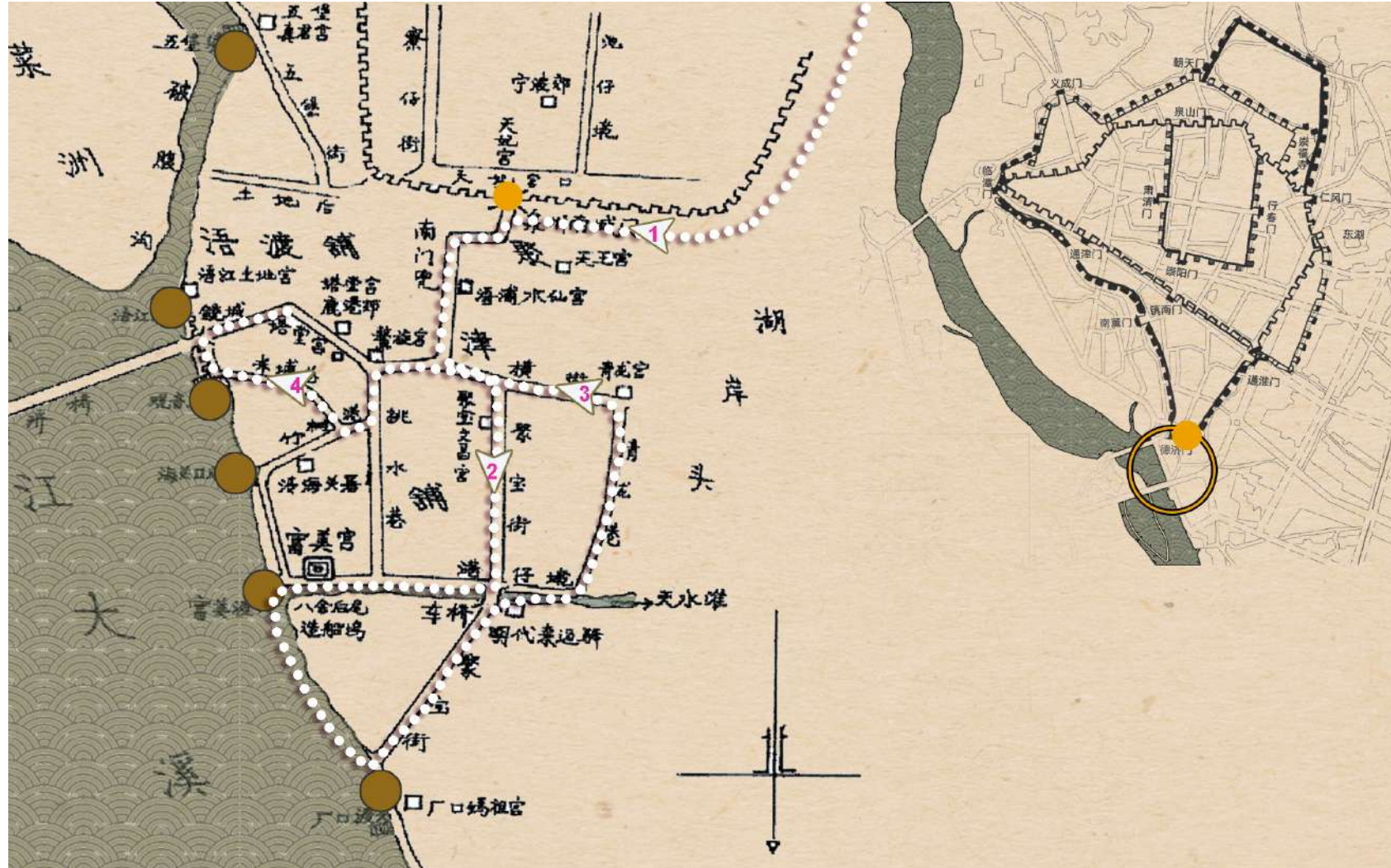


Figure 1: A partial map shows the temples and Dutou (dock) of Jubao in late Qing dynasty (1644-1912 AD) and its location in Carp City. Edited by author, source from Fumei Gong committee, Quanjun Fumei Gong Gazette (1997)

I am choosing the area of Jubao and its embankment docks as an example (Figure 1). Because Jubao was where the traders from ‘ten thousand’ nations landed, during the Song (960-1279 AD) and Yuan (1279-1368 AD) dynasties, following the rising tide, it was where the ancient custom-house, currency exchange stations were situated. Jubao means ‘treasure accumulating,’ originated from the name of the main street in this area. And just as its name implies, the street was the bazaar to gather and link goods and peoples together for exchange. Locals also call this area Chengnan, meaning ‘South of the City,’ as this area was historically located between the river Jin and the southmost city gate, Deji gate. Both in a geographic and social sense, Jubao had become both a ‘city’ in its own right and a ‘harbor.’ But it was also where the city and the harbor areas intersected. If I were to compare Jubao with Marco Polo’s hometown: Venice, I would say it was like the Rialto bridge area where the trade and finical activities of that city happened, but in a sense, it was also like the Arsenale for some specific periods in history.

As stated by Wang¹, the meaning of Chengnan contains the *secret of history*². The south field outside the city gate had traditionally been a pure farming and fishing urbs, inhabited by the peasants. Followed the development of the international trading activities, Chengnan gradually yet powerfully influenced the walled city but still was not entirely adapted to its civis system. It was in such a delicate phenomenon, Jubao revealed an identity of being Michel Foucault's heterotopia³, as it was a real space that existed alongside Carp City's everyday spaces. Jubao bore the traits of a heterotopia because it reflected the dynamic cultural landscape of the port city it belonged to; It was not a freely-accessible place as people arrived and left with the purpose of commerce exchange; Also, both the attributes of the harbor and city had been juxtaposing with each other simultaneously in this place. Such a characteristic will be more explicit and intriguing following in my actual footsteps.

The French term *flânerie* means the act of strolling was best to describe my roam in Jubao that started from the ruin of Deji Gate and reached the river. Inspired by Walter Benjamin's essays through his strolling, the paper was composed of my reflective observation from the current urbs of the area. Jubao is a picturesque and idle township today. The layout largely remains as what it was: the main commercial streets, the mansions of rich and elites, the temples dedicated to different spirits, but the activities and participators have gone. There is no

actual historical map of the area available to my knowledge, yet from the descriptions, we can read that '*the layout of the streets and alleys was like a spider net*'⁴ where merchants arrived with their small laden boats by means of the canals. We can perceive the rich variety of the spaces here: mixed, spontaneous and diverse, yet all were very much dedicated to exchanging and communication. The essence of each crossing point of the street grids and intersections with the network of the canal were influenced by and supportive of the individual activities related to commerce.

Marco Polo described the harbor of Quanzhou as a sprawling waterfront teeming with camphorwood junks propelled by huge rattan sails.⁵ Today the debate about which of the township's current ports was the exact one mentioned by the famous Venetian traveler is still ongoing⁶ and highly likely will never be resolved. While the Jubao bund was descriptive of an image of Quanzhou's heydays, the impression of Marco Polo remained generalized and he did not speak about any particular harbor structures nor how the dock men might have worked. Yet today, all of the piers or docks have disappeared from this area. And we have no traces of the Middle-Age port structures. Hence, my investigation suggests to discover the meanings of Jubao's space through the here and now of its urban environment.

1 Wang, *Jubao Chengnan: A Human Ecological Investigation of the 'Garden of Minnan Cultural Ecology'* (2016), p.33

2 *Ibid*

3 Foucault, *Of other spaces, Heterotopias*, Translated from *Architecture, Mouvement, Continuité* no.5 (1984), p.46-49

4 Zhuang, quote from Wang, *Jubao Chengnan: A Human Ecological Investigation of the 'Garden of Minnan Cultural Ecology'* (2016)

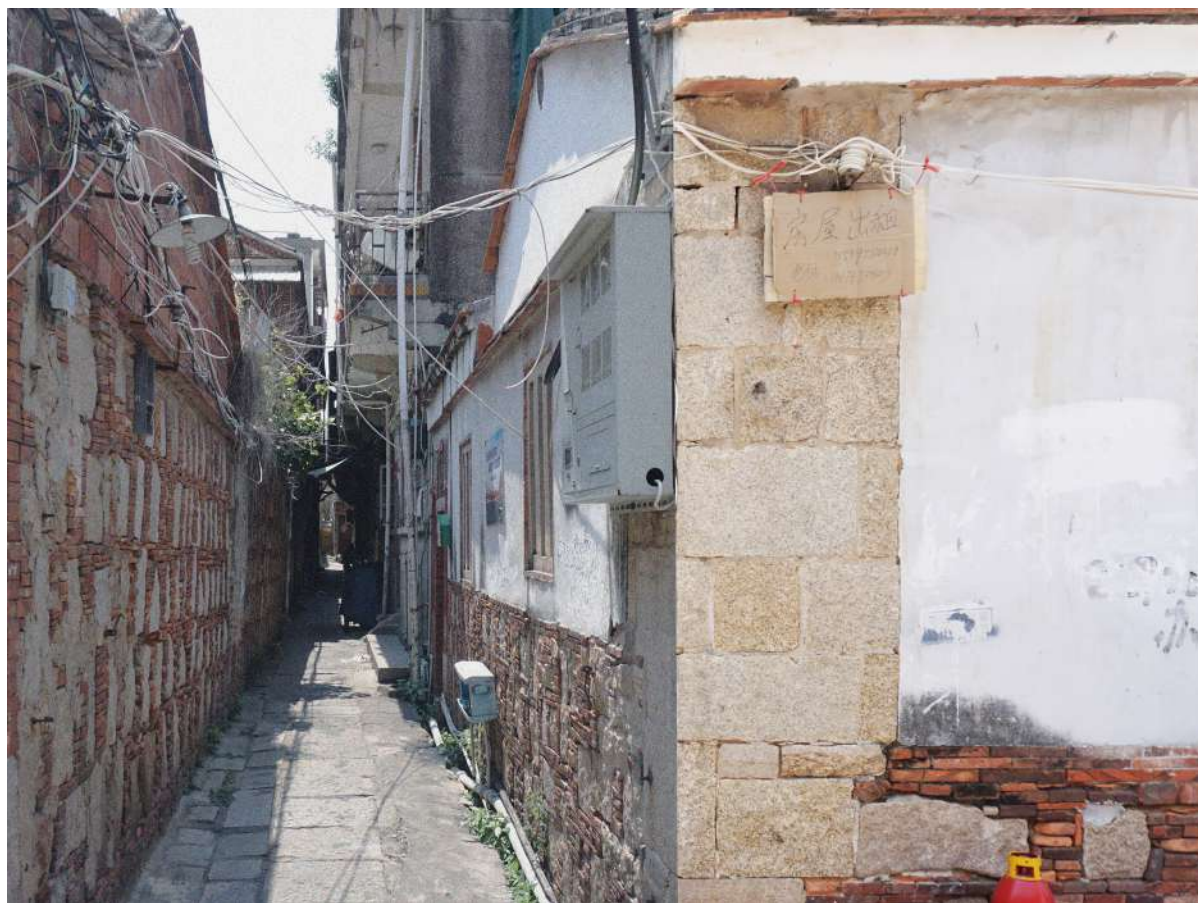
5 It was not the original words from Marco Polo. The summarized description was adopted from Bordewich, *A fabled City from China's Past* (1993)

6 Some said it was the Jubao port, some suggested Houzhu port which is further to the east at the estuary of river Luo.

A picturesque scene of the “entrance” of Jubao taken from the ruin of Deji Gate, which was an isolated component nominated as a potential UNESCO World Heritage Site. Such an essence of Quanzhou is what the State Party and government are promoting .



Typical scenes in Jubao showing the juxtaposition of deserted historical house and the still-in-use structures occupied with daily activities; And the intersections of streets and alleys remain enticing for a historical imagination.



2.1 Canals

An important feature that helped to identify Jubao with both city and harbor were the canals that ran through the township to access the river directly. In the past, the canal was like the lymphatic system of Jubao, assuring the circulation of trade, absorbing the necessary nutrition for the town, yet keep Jubao healthy and resilient.

While in the 1960s still, Wu described the treasures arriving upon the canals or the smell of the salted fish and clams⁷, today it is the stink of the open ditches that affront the visitors' nose. The trenches of the canal are lined with granite parapets on each side and some parts have an extra railing. The water runs quite a bit deeper than its flanking walkway and the embankments are visible. The water is turbid and still and announces the cessation of mobility. On a hot summer day, the motionless green trees and the green water provide us with a view of tranquility (Figure 2&3). This scene is ubiquitous in Carp City. The canals are called Bagua⁸ trenches and date back to the Tang dynasty, built originally as moats and open sewers. While the fortress of the walled city has been modified, extended and in the end destroyed, the water system remains. The picturesque scene belies the smell and the burning sunlight reflected from the dry pavement in the temperature of 40 degrees Celsius, and on my walk, I was able to find some respite next to the railings under the lush trees in an improvised corner set up for tea (Figure 4).

The shop owner of this little haven corners told me the canals used to be lifeblood of the neighborhood. Their water was essential to wash rice grain and clothing. For the children, they were a wonderland. On old photographs, we can see that the canals look much broader, and the water was clean. Maybe after the 1970s, they stopped functioning as they always had, they were forgotten and despised, the people started dumping waste into the water. The shop owner continued: 'It is like the mechanical components; if you don't activate and maintain them, they will not work for you. In fact, the government and community have been monitoring the canals regularly, including the maintenance of the hard surface of the road, railings and the water purifying system. The smell is much better now.' It is evident that the shop owner and his family are happy about the extra outside space in front of their property and enjoy the tranquility of this outdoor place to sit on warm summer nights. Along the canals, this family was not alone to ignore the smell of the canal. There was a young couple tenderly chatting with each other while their bicycles leaned casually on the railing.

But such interventions are not encouraged, because 'orderliness' both spatially and in behavior is the accepted goal of the city's managers and leaders.

In the past, when the washed and steamed rice was brought to the dinner table, the water and the wet stoned pavements symbolized happiness and contentment.⁹ The water system was the focus of the respective neighborhoods, with each individual section of the canal marked out as places for people to gather (Figure 5). People worked with and embraced the natural landscape as a hybrid between culture and geography, with different locations distinctive in their spatial and social character. Eventually, such activities became the idiographic entity of these spaces.

Today, the canal ditches are the reflective objects of people's memories as the spirit of the place and the society behind this. The tangibility of these memories can be found in areas such as the tea corner rather than in the refurbished canals themselves. Perhaps because the canal is no longer really necessary as a functional infrastructure to the economic mechanisms of the city, but Quanzhouers insist on communicating this historical space in their memories through contemporary situations in the today of the city. From the geomantic point of view, despite the loss of its function for the residents, water is still essential for the Carp. Today as part of the urban fabric, canals are more like a decorative water feature; consistent maintenance is part and parcel of the enjoyment of this natural element as an oversized public garden landscape. As Feuchtwang described, *Chinese gardens are designed to relate sentiment inherent in the surrounding*.¹⁰ Quanzhouers can co-create this space by understanding themselves as a feature of the landscape juxtaposed with other objects there. For Quanzhouers this is the meaning of this garden.

Both the historical and contemporary experiences interacted with this element of the nature. Such an interactivity was ingrained in the stable yet changing existential meanings over time. As a mnemonic device, the environment continues to fluctuate. This is then internalized as a palimpsest of personal, social and spatial experience. Within the context of the UNESCO World Heritage application, it is more meaningful for us to reassemble the stories that the location can tell. And if indeed the preservation and celebration of the historic environment are the genuine goal,¹¹ it will be necessary to those changing perspectives back into the everydayness of Quanzhou.

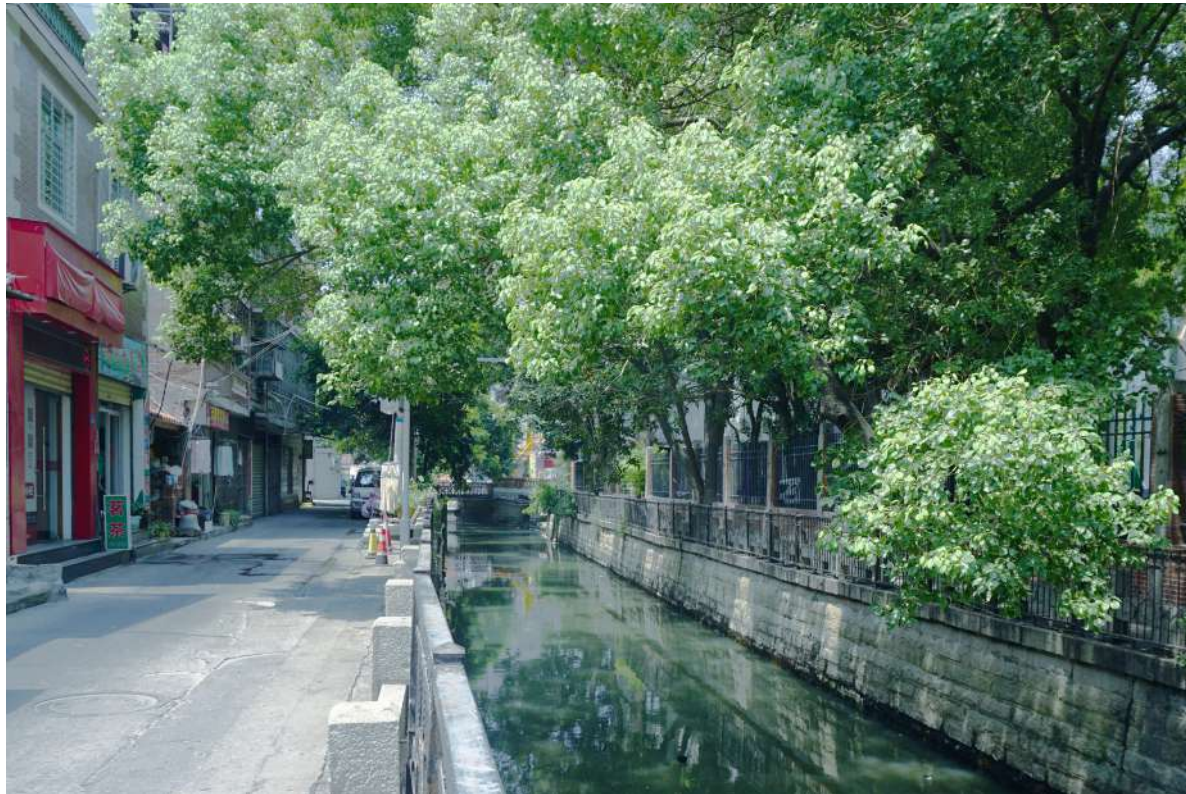
7 Wu, *The memory of river docks in Quanzhou* 泉州内港码头记忆 (2012). It depicts a life scene in the area between 1960s to 1980s

8 Bagua, or Pa kua, are eight symbols used in Taoist cosmology to represent the fundamental principles of reality, seen as a range of eight interrelated concepts.

9 In that era, people get the groceries based on the received tokens from the commune. The society operated as the form of People's commune which was known as collective activity, such as labor and meal preparation. Food and other groceries were much more precious compared with the ones today.

10 Feuchtwang, *Three gestures in a poetics of place-Chinese settlement and disruption* (2005)

11 The author concerns about the genuine goal of the historical preservation actions, as very often, decision makers show the great interest in developing heritage into a commercialism-driven tourism and a potential cultural Chauvinism.



Top Figure 2: Image of canal taken at the Wuan Tou near Deji Gate
Bottom Figure 3: Image of narrow canal taken at Mipu Alley near the embankment

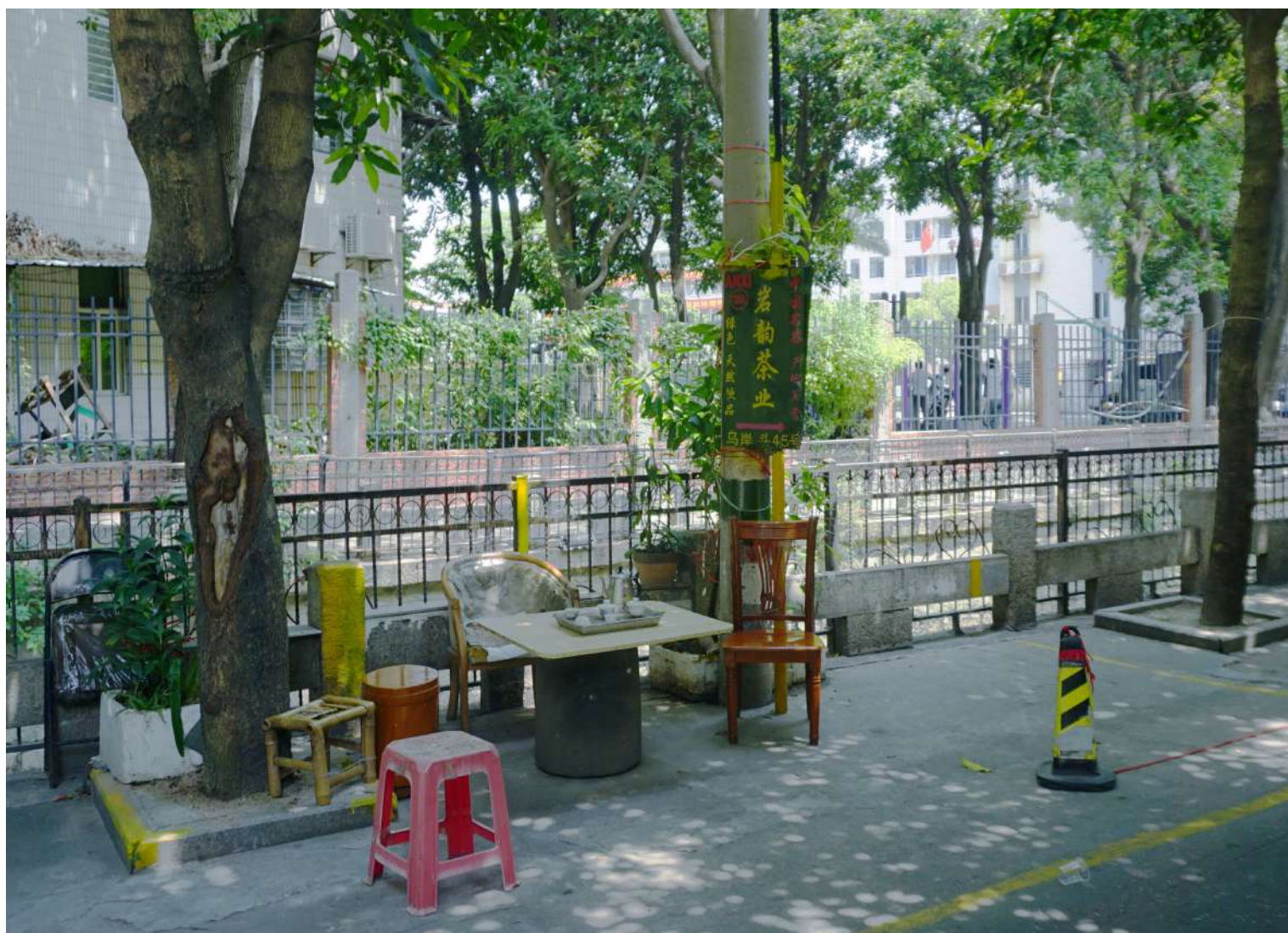


Figure 4: Tea corner next to the canal at Wu'an Tou



Figure 5: Historical photo shows the canal at Che qiao tou in 1958 (the central area of Jubao). Source from <http://www.qztqz.com/p/5168.html>